A little practice. Every day.

A shared reading and writing routine for Donatello, building towards Grade 4.

30 minutes after school + 10 minutes at bedtime

Monday–Friday. The same order, journal, book and word list at both homes.

01 Read & talk — 10 min

Read aloud, reread a short part, then tell back the meaning.

02 My journal — 12 min

Say the ideas aloud, then write about gratitude, the day and a story.

03 My words — 5 min

Practise this week’s words from memory. Check and repair.

04 Neat writing — 3 min

Practise a few careful letters, then one useful sentence.

05 Bedtime book — 10 min

Don chooses. Read together, listen or enjoy a book independently.

One bag. One routine. Two homes.

Keep the journal, current reading book, pencil and weekly word sheet in one folder in his bag. Mark the next page and word-set number before it changes homes. Either adult can pick up from there.

Friday: the story page replaces the usual journal; the word check replaces word practice. At weekends, keep the enjoyable reading. No catch-up pile.

Read for meaning.

10 minutes: about 7 minutes reading, 1 minute rereading and 2 minutes talking.

Choose a comfortable text

Use a school reader or a book he enjoys. As a rough guide, he should read about 95 out of 100 words without help and explain the passage. Easier books still build confidence and fluent reading.

Help with the word, then keep the meaning

Give him a brief chance to use the letter sounds or a familiar word part. If he is still stuck after a few seconds, say the word, let him repeat it, and reread the sentence. Avoid guessing from the picture.

Reread one small part

Choose 2–4 sentences. Read them naturally to him, then let him read them again, noticing full stops and expression. On Wednesday or Friday, revisit a favourite short passage.

Talk about what he read

Ask: “What happened first, next and last?” Then: “Why do you think that? Show me a clue.” For a fact book: “Tell me two things you learned and explain one.”

How much? Try roughly 300–400 words read aloud in the reading block; build towards 400–600 when comfortable. These are home planning guides, not quotas. Stop at 10 minutes, including the chat. Record pages instead of counting every word.

Let him choose between two books

Funny and illustrated: try Dog Man or The Bad Guys.

Short chapters: try Dragon Masters, Owl Diaries or Press Start!

Free and shorter: Book Dash stories to read or print.

Borrow or sample a page first. There is no one-book-a-week deadline.

At bedtime, the adult can read aloud while Don listens. He can also follow an audiobook or read for himself. Keep this part for enjoyment.

This is what “finished” looks like.

An invented example, not a record of Donatello’s day. Eight sentences; 78 words.

01 Thank you for

I am grateful that Dad helped me fix my bike. I felt happy because we could ride together again.

02 What happened

First, we looked for the missing bolt in the garage. Then, I found it under a dusty box. After that, we fixed the wheel and rode to the park.

03 My story

A tiny dragon was hiding inside my helmet. It sneezed and turned my bike into a rocket. I grabbed the handlebars and flew over the tallest tree in the park.

Say it. Write it. Read it back.

Use the 12 minutes as a guide: 2 to talk and plan, 8 to write, 2 to reread and improve one thing. An adult can write 2–3 needed words in a small word bank before he starts.

Build up: start with 1–2 sentences under each heading. Grow towards 2 gratitude + 3 recount + 3 story sentences (about 60–100 words altogether). Increase when he is comfortable, not because the calendar says so.

Fifteen ways to begin.

Choose one, invent your own, or continue yesterday’s adventure. The question helps the next sentence.

01 **The day the LEGO city came alive.**
Who needed your help?

02 **A robot that only speaks in football scores.**
What was it trying to tell you?

03 **The drum that nobody was allowed to hit.**
What happened when someone did?

04 **I found a door behind the bookshelf.**
Where did it lead?

05 **The night the moon went out.**
Who could switch it on again?

06 **My dog learned one word and used it against me.**
Which word changed everything?

07 **The smallest dinosaur in the world.**
Where could you keep it safe?

08 **We swapped places for a day.**
What was the hardest part?

09 **The treehouse had one more room than we built.**
What was inside?

10 **A goalkeeper who was afraid of the ball.**
Who helped the goalkeeper be brave?

11 **The puddle that was a portal.**
What was on the other side?

12 **Everything I touched turned to jelly.**
How could you stop it?

13 **The last child on Earth, and the Wi-Fi still worked.**
Who sent the first message?

14 **A snail that wanted to win a race.**
What clever plan did it try?

15 **The secret the ants were keeping.**
Why did they finally tell you?

Three-sentence story: someone + a place; a problem; what they do next. It can end today or continue tomorrow.

Five minutes. A useful repeat.

Eight words for the week: six with a spelling pattern and two everyday words.

Learn the sounds and the surprising part

Say the word and use it in a sentence. Listen for its sounds and match them to letters. Mark the part that needs extra attention: in **said**, the letters **ai** represent the /e/ sound. Everyday words are not all irregular; use the parts he already knows.

MON	Read all eight. Practise words 1–4: look, say, cover, write once, check.
TUE	Read all eight. Practise words 5–8 with the same cover-and-write method.
WED	Recall words 1–4 again; revisit mistakes. Say a sentence using one word.
THU	Recall words 5–8 again; revisit mistakes. Use one in today's journal.
FRI	Cover the list. Adult says each word, uses it in a sentence, and repeats it. Don writes it. Check together; choose up to two to revisit next week.

After a mistake: show the correct word, notice the part to fix, cover it and try once more. Stop at five minutes. Use unfinished words first next time; no rows of copying.

Three minutes of handwriting

Use the letter formation taught at school. Choose two letters from today's words; make each carefully three times. Then copy one short sentence. Check comfortable size, spaces and letters sitting on the line.

Example: practise b and d, then write "The duck is back."
Journal focus: Mon capitals/full stops · Tue join with because, but or so · Wed past tense · Thu one precise detail · Fri story order.

More ideas for the journal

Gratitude: Who helped? What made you laugh? What did you enjoy? Say why.
Explaining: How did you build it, play it or solve it? Use first, then and finally. This can replace the recount for a day.

Word sets 1-6

A suggested sequence, not a Grade 4 spelling standard. School or tutor words can replace a set.

01 -ck after a short vowel

back · kick · sock · duck · pack · rock

Everyday words: said · was

02 sh and ch

shop · chip · ship · much · wish · chat

Everyday words: they · there

03 th and wh

this · that · thin · when · which · with

Everyday words: because · some

04 ng and nk

sing · long · ring · bank · pink · thank

Everyday words: could · would

05 Long a / i with final e

came · game · time · ride · five · name

Everyday words: people · friend

06 Long o / u with final e

home · hope · note · bone · tube · use

Everyday words: again · any

Read the list before choosing it. If already secure, move to the next set. If still learning, repeat it. Agree the same set at both homes; replace up to two new words with review words rather than adding extras.

Word sets 7-12

A suggested sequence, not a Grade 4 spelling standard. School or tutor words can replace a set.

07 **ai and ay**

rain · wait · train · play · day · paint

Everyday words: many · school

08 **ee and ea**

see · tree · green · eat · leaf · sleep

Everyday words: house · water

09 **oa and ow as in snow**

boat · coat · road · grow · show · float

Everyday words: want · should

10 **igh and y as in fly**

high · light · night · right · try · fly

Everyday words: come · done

11 **ar and or**

car · star · farm · hard · fork · storm

Everyday words: our · your

12 **er, ir and ur**

her · bird · girl · turn · hurt · first

Everyday words: been · where

Read the list before choosing it. If already secure, move to the next set. If still learning, repeat it. Agree the same set at both homes; replace up to two new words with review words rather than adding extras.

My daily journal

My ideas first. My careful words next.

Date: _____ **Words I might need:** _____

1 Thank you for

I am grateful for … It mattered to me because …

2 What happened

First … Then … After that …

3 My story

Someone in a place … A problem … What happened next …

Read it back. Pick one improvement.

☐ Capital & full stop ☐ Spaces ☐ Makes sense

Use fewer lines while building confidence. Extra ideas can continue in your journal.

My Friday story

Choose a story from this week. Add a problem, an action and an ending.

Date: _____ **Title:** _____

Beginning
Who? Where?

Middle
What went wrong?

Ending
How was it solved?

Say the plan aloud. Aim for 6–8 sentences as you build confidence; use a new paragraph for each part.

☐ A beginning ☐ A problem or action ☐ An ending

One detail I improved: _____

This replaces the daily journal. A clear short story is enough; continue next time if needed.

My weekly words

Look. Say. Cover. Write. Check. Fix only the part that needs it.

Week / set: _____ **Starting date:** _____

#	My word / pattern	First try	Later try

Cover the word AND earlier attempts. Rows 1–4: Mon/Wed. Rows 5–8: Tue/Thu.

1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			
7			
8			

My sentence using one of these words:

_____

_____

Friday • cover all work above

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____
6. _____
7. _____
8. _____

Keep practising these next week: _____

Our week, in one place.

Keep this in the folder so either home can carry on. A few ticks and the next page are enough.

Week beginning: _____ **Word set:** _____

Book: _____

Day	Pages read / next page	Read	Journal	Words	Letters
Mon		☐	☐	☐	☐
Tue		☐	☐	☐	☐
Wed		☐	☐	☐	☐
Thu		☐	☐	☐	☐
Fri		☐	☐	☐	☐

"Read" includes the short conversation. Friday's journal tick means the Friday story; words means the word check. Bedtime reading is for enjoyment and needs no tick.

Ready for the next home

Next book page: _____ **Continue word set:** _____

One thing that went well:

_____

One thing to practise next:

_____

What progress looks like.

Use these as planning guides. Agree school expectations with Donatello's teacher.

Our home goals

Reading: Five short sessions a week. Work towards 400–600 words within the 10-minute read-and-talk block when comfortable; accuracy and understanding come first.

Meaning: Retell the main events in order and answer one "why" question using a clue. With factual reading, tell two facts and explain one.

Writing: Build from 1–2 sentences per heading to about 60–100 words across the three entries. On Fridays, build a connected story with a beginning, middle and end.

Spelling: Work towards remembering all eight words over time. Use Friday's attempts to choose what to revisit; there is no pass mark.

Handwriting: Letters are readable, words have spaces and writing sits on the line. Compare with his own earlier work.

School benchmarks: keep the context

For **English Home Language**, CAPS lists Grade 4 essays of **100–120 words in 2–3 paragraphs**, and short stories of **120–140 words in 3–5 paragraphs**. These are school task lengths to build towards, not daily journal quotas. [1]

The DBE's **English First Additional Language** benchmark is **70 correct words per minute at the end of Grade 4**, developed largely from no-fee-school data. It is not a universal English Home Language standard or proof of readiness. Ask the teacher to interpret fluency, accuracy and comprehension together. [2]

Print only what you need

Keep: pages 1–7 and 12 as the adult guide.
Repeat: page 8 for Mon–Thu; page 9 on Friday; pages 10–11 once a week.
Settings: A4, actual size / 100%, one-sided for writing pages. Black and white works. A lined notebook can replace the printed worksheets.

SOURCES • clickable in the PDF • checked 10 November 2026

[1] DBE: English Home Language CAPS, Grades 4–6, §3.2.3–4

[2] DBE: English First Additional Language benchmarks (2022)

[3] Reading Rockets: Fluency — An Introduction

[4] Reading Rockets: A New Model for Teaching High-Frequency Words